

HALO leaked

Halo has been leaked before it's ready to release

Microsoft messenger

Microsoft messenger users can now chat with Facebook users, it's the only messenger directly connects to Facebook chat



Life at Mar Sara



Starcraft II's isometric perspective

Genre: RTS

Studio: Blizzard Entertainment

Publisher: Activision

***Platforms:** Windows, Mac OSX

Exploring Zerg's terrain

Fans of Blizzard games have been waiting with bated breath ever since *StarCraft II* was officially announced back in 2007. Blizzard has a unique reputation in the ever-shrinking world of PC games development. Hence, news of a new project – outside of WoW – was enough to induce bouts of hysteria, even if one is not necessarily a big fan of RTS genre.

Raynor's crusade

StarCraft II is set merely four years after the incidents in the Brood Wars, which means that most of the characters from the original game are still around. Jim Raynor is a fugitive from the law and he is gathering force and resources to give a fitting reply to Mengk's betrayal, which led to Kerrigan's transformation into the Queen of Blades. Joining him on his mission are other returning characters like Tycus and Zeratul. Entwined with Raynor's quest for vengeance, is the ever increasing threat from Kerrigan's brood that looks poised to overwhelm all other life in the universe. While Kerrigan and Mensk strive for dominance, Raynor is torn between his hatred for Mensk and his love for Kerrigan.

Solo Campaign

StarCraft II single-player campaign pans across several planets – some of which are new to the series while others will be familiar to those who have played the original game. Each mission has one or more primary objectives and may also have several bonus objectives.

Completing bonus mission is either rewarded by credits or by research points. Credits are used for multiple purposes – from hiring mercenary groups to

fight by your side, to purchasing permanent upgrades for buildings and units. Zerg and Protoss research points can also be earned during certain single-player missions and these can be used to unlock powerful upgrades for your existing units and building, or they can be used to unlock entirely new units.

At any given point in the game, there can be several missions available and these can be attempted in any order. Also at certain points during the campaign, the player needs to make a choice between two missions and this choice takes the storyline on a slightly different trajectory. The missions themselves have enough variety – either in terms of specific challenges or the planets' terrain – to keep things fresh and interesting right until the end. *StarCraft II* also has a few Protoss missions and this helps in breaking the monotony of Terran missions. The only major gripe we have about the single-player campaign is that it has an inconclusive and underwhelming ending.

After beating the single-player campaign, players can choose to replay missions on higher difficulties or attempt the mission again to earn any locked achievement points. Besides this, there is also a challenge mode that works like rock-paper-scissors and helps the player analyze the effectiveness of one unit type against another.

Battle on the net

For many, *StarCraft II* is all about multiplayer face-offs and they couldn't care less about the single-player campaign. Blizzard's lauded Battle.net system has received a major overhaul to accommodate contemporary features and improvement of familiar features.

StarCraft II features a multiplayer practice league which is essentially a series of unranked competitive matches meant as practice to hone your skills. And then of course there are the ranked matches – the big leagues of competitive multiplayer matches. Winning games and meeting certain objectives rewards the player will achievement points and rank-points. In our experience so far, Battle.net has performed admirably – able to find accurate matches quickly. The matches themselves were pretty smooth and entirely lag-free. However, we should point out that we are yet to engage in frantic online battles with large armies facing each other off.

Sum of all parts

The game's war-rules are fundamentally the same – securing mineral and vespene gas deposit are keys to sustaining an army. Efficiently wiping out the opposing army or enduring attacks – is down to knowing units' weaknesses and abilities.

Single-player experience was largely an enjoyable experience and apart from the unsatisfactory conclusion, we do not have any major complaints. On the multiplayer front however, it could be a different situation all together. I am not someone who often participates in multiplayer over the Internet, so my expectations maybe a lot different from someone who spends most his game-time in the cyberspace.

If one looks beyond some of the inexplicable and annoying business decisions, they may find a pretty solid game in *StarCraft II*. However, looking beyond these issues may warrant a big heart and deep pockets. **d**